

Pocket Pet Design Report

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Table of Contents

Top-Level Design Description.....	3
Design Pillars	3
Audience & Marketing.....	3
Core Gameplay	4
Controls.....	4
Gameplay Balance & Pacing.....	5
Tone & Aesthetics.....	5
Narrative	6
Business Model.....	6

Top-Level Design Description

Pocket Pet is a Simulation / Nurture game where the player takes care of many virtual pets. The goal is to keep all your pets happy and in good health.

Design Pillars

The below design pillars identify the types of fun which are key to the user experience

- Love
- Physical Activity
- Application of Ability

Love	Physical Activity	Application of Ability
Players form an emotional bond with their virtual pet, wanting to care for it and keep it happy and healthy. This is the primary motivator.	To show affection, the player must physically bring the device close to their body. This makes affection something the player does with their body instead of just clicking a button.	The skill is consistent care. Players learn when to feed, play, or wash the pet. The release decision also adds a meaningful choice as letting go of one pet to try another has emotional weight.

Audience & Marketing

This is designed to be an offline game played via mobile devices. It is a single player Simulation / Nurture game. This game is available on android devices only. This game is aimed at casual players looking for a low-pressure and short-session game rather than a competitive or high stakes one. With its simple controls and an easy release option for making the game easier. This makes it more accessible to younger and family audiences. As its fully offline and single player it means there's nothing social for a parent to worry about. But something to note is that the Simulation / Nurture genre has always pulled in a nostalgic audience also, so the appeal isn't strictly bound by age.

Core Gameplay

From the adoption screen players can browse available pets and adopt any they like. Adopted pets live on the My Pets screen, each showing their current hunger and happiness levels. Tapping a pet brings you to the care screen. On this screen you have 3 options to interact with it.

Players can feed a pet by pressing the cake. This will bring the pet to the kitchen where they will eat a slice of cake. Their hunger status will increase by 1. Players can embrace your pet by clicking on the heart button and bringing their device close to their heart. If done successfully the pet jumps, gaining happiness. Players can clean their pet by clicking the sponge. This will bring the pet to a bath where it will stay for a while, it's happiness will increase by 1. Each pet's stats decrease over time so there's always something to do.

Players can adopt multiple pets and view them all (along with their stats) on the home screen. If the player finds they have too many pets and cannot keep up with their care they can choose to release any pets they want.

If the player wants to adopt more pets they can adopt as many as they want from the adoption screen.

Controls

Tap: The main input type the game needs. By tapping the screen players can browse and adopt pets. They can also interact with all the care buttons by tapping on them.

Proximity Sensor: When the player taps the heart icon on the care screen and bring their device close to their body, the sensor detects the movement. When both of these actions are done in succession the pet gains happiness.

Gameplay Balance & Pacing

The game runs entirely in real time while it's open. Hunger and happiness each sit on a scale from 0-10. Every 60 seconds both the hunger and happiness lose 1 point per pet. So, a neglected pet drops from full to empty in 10 minutes.

Since every adopted pet loses hunger and happiness on the same clock simultaneously this means that difficulty scales naturally with the player's collection size. One pet is easy to maintain, but five pets all needing care will force the player to prioritise which one needs attention right now.

If players are struggling to keep up with the load, then releasing pets is the direct answer to this. It lets the player lower the difficulty to something they can manage but players may have a bond to their virtual pets and will need to consider carefully before releasing them.

Tone & Aesthetics

I wanted a pastel style for the UI and I knew I wanted the background to be Frutiger Aero theme.

Pastel Palette



Frutiger Aero



Narrative

This is a singleplayer game without any explicit narrative. I do not intend to have dialog or characters speaking.

Business Model

Pocket Pets is a free-to-download Android game with no monetisation model. It will be made freely available to all users with no ads and no premium tiers.

The game is being developed as a portfolio project to demonstrate skills in game design and development. Its primary value is in the player experience and the learning gained through building it, rather than revenue generation.